

Search engines

Search engines organise for you the vast streams of information on the internet and even help you make sense of it all. Consequently, which search engine to use has always been a matter of contention for web users, especially with Bing entering the fray.

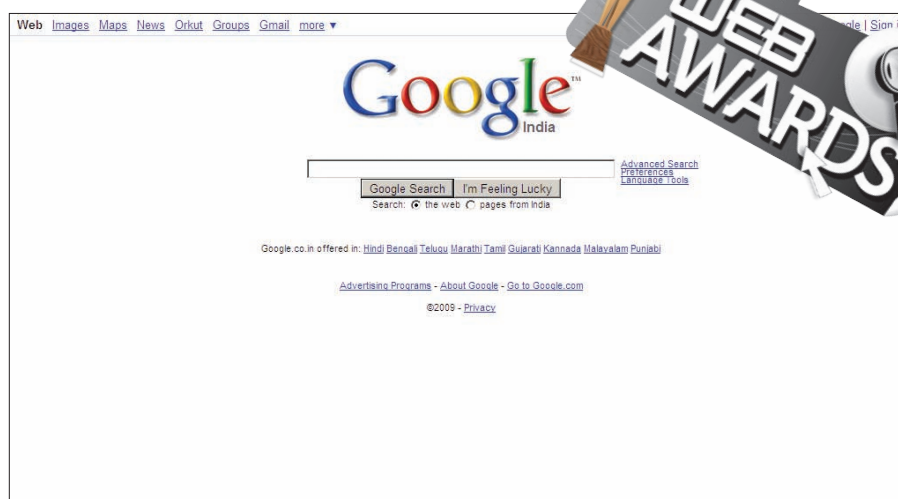
To drill down to the short-listed candidates, we ran a few exploratory searches on the most popular as well as many obscure engines, including **ask.com**, **cuil.com**, **exalead** and **alltheweb**. We

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The purse strings are loosening, and it appears as much as \$80 to \$100 million is likely to fall out, as Microsoft decides to boldly enter what is clearly Google's domain; Search. It intends to create a new search engine which it believes will show people what they've always been missing in search results. Although a casual observer might ask "based on what experience"? To read more, go to <http://www.thinkdigit.com/d/thinkdigit/mvsg/>

found that most of them could not deliver consistently relevant results, especially when it came to local search terms.

Since at the time of testing Yahoo and Bing still haven't consolidated their backends, we've considered them separately. To eliminate user bias, on certain search terms, we decided to use the BlindSearch (blindsearch.fejus.com) tool. The results are displayed in three separate columns which



keep changing randomly with each term. Each relevant result appearing closest to the top was awarded a point. We created a mixed bag of search terms in different categories. Some terms were general, such as **Indian economic policy**, while a whole category was devoted to terms of local relevance such as **sweet shop mumbai**, **thermocool balls near vashi**, **Bandra-worli sea link map**, **ganesh chaturthi**, and **roti**. The most fun category of search terms was the set of terms used to determine the indexing capabilities of the search engines. Here we had to come up with random, obscure strings of sentences such as **evolution of "samurai crabs"**. These would determine if the search engine is capable of crawling for obscure bits of information. Then a whole set of terms were tried that were time sensitive, such as **swine flu** and **Leno show**. Since image

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search is one of the most used features, we settled on a few image terms as well.

In the blind test, Google and Bing ran neck and neck. While Yahoo! didn't garner many points. That put Google and Bing in the lead for the rest of the categories of search. As far as calculations were concerned, both Bing and Google were fairly similar so we decided to raise the bar, and queried **speed of light in furlongs per fortnight**. Google calculator displayed the result correctly, while Bing pointed to the result. Bonus

points for Google on that one.

For local search, let's take the case of **mumbai sweet shop**. Google

returned literally hundreds of results with direct maps and direction support that worked quite well. There were even reviews available for some of the listings. Bing on the other hand returned only a handful of local results; six to be precise. It had map direction and the capability of reviews, but none were available for our search. Also, driving directions didn't work. For **Roti**, Bing, Google and Yahoo! offered similar results. However, Bing showed a few videos right at the top. Other than these, as far as the index size or number of results go, Google was ahead. For images, Google and Bing were almost the same, while Yahoo! certainly lagged behind for difficult searches such as **"Naneghat map"**.

Going by overall scores and relevance of results, Google was the winner. But certainly not by a mile, and Bing is close on its heels. With the imminent integration of the two runners up, Bing may just have some tricks up its sleeve in the near future to overthrow the reigning champion. But Google has also revamped itself with Caffeine, so we're in for a lot of action in the months to come. **d**

SEARCH ENGINES FOR YOUR EVERY NEED

For realtime search

If you want to know what's happening on the internet at any point in time, head over to icerocket.com to search for blogs and blog trends. It's even got a nifty RSS builder tool. Another one is collecta.com; this displays your search results as a continuous flow that's refreshed every few seconds. Head over to oneriot.com or scoopler.com for the latest trending topics in the web 2.0 world from sources such as twitter.com. The trending topics are all neatly sorted into categories: business, technology and music.

For your audio-visual needs

Head over to blinkx.com to search through over 35 million hours of video. Music is more your taste? Go to fizzy.com, simply type the

name of a song and start listening! It's almost too good to be true. (Yes it even searches for, and plays, Bollywood songs).

For the altruist

Goodsearch.com is a search engine powered by Yahoo! with a small difference. It donates 50 per cent of its revenue to the charities and schools designated by its users. So with every search about one cent goes to a charity.

For the best of both worlds

Use scour.com to get results from different search engines displayed together. This web site also offers the possibility of writing comments. Try searching for **digit**. The only problem is that the site is slow.